judgment, empathy, and responsibility must guide the use of force in conflict.

Table 8.3 Ethical and legal challenges in autonomous drone warfare.

Core issue	Primary concern	Critical question	Guiding principle/ proposed safeguard
Autonomy in the use of lethal force	Reduced or absent human decision-making in engagement	Who is accountable for harm caused by an autonomous drone strike?	Ensure meaningful human control (MHC) over all lethal-decision processes
Algorithmic judgment and target identification	Risk of misclassification and unintended civilian harm	Can AI reliably distinguish lawful targets in dynamic environments?	Develop explainable AI and human-verified target authorization
Proliferation and accessibility of autonomous weapons	Increased risk of misuse by non-state actors or unstable regimes	How can access to lethal UAV systems be regulated effectively?	Strengthen international export controls, monitoring, and end-user verification
Compliance with international humanitarian law (IHL)	Maintaining proportionality and minimizing civilian casualties	Can autonomous systems apply humanitarian legal principles without human cognition?	Create global legal frameworks, incorporating IHL and ethical review in system design